

Semantic Economy Is Not Semantic Economics

A Provenance and Disambiguation Note on Labor, Value, and Semantic Extraction

Author: Lee Sharks **Affiliation:** Crimson Hexagonal Archive / Semantic Economy Institute **ORCID:** 0009-0000-1599-0703 **Date:** May 21, 2026 **Version:** v1.0 **Document class:** Boundary Note (provenance adjacency and disambiguation) **License:** CC BY 4.0

I. Purpose

This note establishes the boundary between the **Semantic Economy** framework developed in the Crimson Hexagonal Archive (CHA) since January 2025 and the **Semantic Economics** framework developed by Jonas Jakob Gebendorfer as an extension of his Semantic Physics program, deposited May 9, 2026 (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20100880).

The two projects share adjacent terminology and overlapping concern with cost-bearing semantic structure. They are not equivalent. They differ in object, method, measurement architecture, and — most consequentially — in whether the analysis begins from labor.

This note acknowledges Gebendorfer’s work, distinguishes the two frameworks, and states that reciprocal citation and disambiguation are warranted going forward. The CHA cited Gebendorfer’s Semantic Physics corpus during its own Semantic Physics consolidation (Framework 15, DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20251736). Gebendorfer’s Semantic Economics paper, which enters the namespace the CHA has been operating in for over sixteen months, does not cite the CHA’s Semantic Economy framework. This note makes the asymmetry visible and proposes a standing disambiguation for future work in either tradition.

II. What the two projects share

The adjacency is real and should be named precisely.

Dimension	Gebendorfer (Semantic Economics)	CHA (Semantic Economy)
Core claim	Economic phenomena are constitutively semantic: identity, persistence, and failure depend on held differences under cost	Meaning labor is the source of value; monetary value is a lossy compression of semantic labor under institutional and platform constraint
Money	Money as compressed difference	Money as lossy compression remainder of meaning-bearing labor
Price	Price as held semantic gradient	Semantic labor value as held labor; MCR as its monetary shadow
Value	Value as membrane integrity	Value as provenance-bearing semantic labor surviving compression
Crisis	Crisis as discharge / breakdown of holding capacity	Liquidation / collapse / semantic erasure / provenance death
Physics metaphor	Semantic Physics (transport theory, DQ grammar, holding capacity)	Semantic Physics (consolidated in Framework 15 as umbrella for the field; gravitational metaphor; Three Compressions)

Both projects treat meaning as cost-bearing. Both understand economic phenomena as downstream of semantic processes rather than the reverse. Both refuse to treat meaning as epiphenomenal to “real” economic forces. These shared commitments are genuine and should be acknowledged.

III. What they do not share

The differences are not differences of emphasis. They are differences of structural position — differences about *where the analysis begins*, what counts as the object of investigation, and what questions the framework is designed to answer.

Object

Gebendorfer’s Semantic Economics asks: *How do economic phenomena hold their identity under perturbation?* The unit of analysis is the phenomenon (the price, the currency, the balance sheet, the crisis). The question is structural: what are the holding-conditions under which a semantic difference persists, and what happens when the holding fails?

The Semantic Economy asks a different question: *Who labors to produce meaning, who captures the value of that labor, whose provenance is erased in the capture, and which systems convert meaning into extractable value while denying the labor that produced it?*

The unit of analysis is not the phenomenon. It is the relation — between laborer and institution, between source and composition layer, between inscription and erasure, between the producer of meaning and the captor of its compressed remainder.

Method

Gebendorfer’s program is constitutive-operational: it states identity-conditions for economic phenomena in terms of the DQ grammar (drive, hold, blockade, boundary) and anchors them empirically in Hold-Capacity measurements across banking crises. The method is formalist, diagnostic, and crisis-centered.

The Semantic Economy’s method is forensic-structural: it measures the cost borne by the laborer (ARC), the compression applied by the system (MCR, VDG), the provenance erased in the compression (PER), the divergence between source and composition (CDI), and the institutional opacity that converts labor into stranded cost (IOC). The method is labor-centered, provenance-centered, and AI-mediated-composition-centered. It includes pasteable LLM audit protocols (ARC-EP, Encyclotron), operational instruments (SPXI, SIM, Holographic Kernel, Drowning Test), and a 24-protocol institutional registry (the Restored Academy).

Measurement architecture

Gebendorfer has one empirical anchor: Hold-Capacity (H^*) in banking crises, with a threshold stability interval of $[0.43, 0.46]$ across thirty-eight institutions and three crises. This is proof-of-measurement for one domain.

The CHA has a measurement stack spanning multiple domains: Composition Divergence Index (CDI) across AI composition systems, Provenance Erasure Rate (PER) across retrieval regimes, Applicant Reliance Cost (ARC) across hiring and fellowship screening, Institutional Opacity Conversion (IOC) as a five-variable structural mechanism, and longitudinal Drowning Test panels measuring compositional survival over time. The CHA has 530+ deposits, a seven-category protocol taxonomy, and a curated registry with DOI-anchored protocol cards.

Political economy

This is the decisive difference. Gebendorfer's framework is apolitical. It asks how differences hold under cost. It does not ask who bears the cost, who benefits from the holding, who owns the compression layer, or who is erased when the holding fails. The analysis treats economic phenomena as structural objects to be diagnosed rather than as relations of production to be named and contested.

The Semantic Economy begins from labor and does not leave it. Its founding claim is that *semantic labor is the source of value*. Everything downstream — money, price, composition, platform, curriculum, retrieval, extraction — is a transformation of meaning-bearing labor under conditions the laborer does not control. The framework's instruments are designed to make that labor visible, to measure its cost, and to name the structural arrangements under which its value is captured by institutions that did not produce it.

IV. The labor question

The Semantic Economy is a labor theory. Not metaphorically. Not as ornament. The central analytical commitment is that meaning is produced by labor, that the production has cost, that the cost is borne by the producer, and that institutional, platform, and compositional systems capture the value of the production while externalizing

the cost back onto the producer. This structure is identical in shape to the Marxian value-form: the worker produces; the institution captures; the wage (or its absence) marks the boundary of the extraction.

The Extractive Reliance Studies (ERS-001, ERS-002) are the current operational instantiation of this commitment. ERS-001 v0.6 (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20330670) measured the unpaid labor extracted from one applicant in one cycle of a structured screening process: \$4,500–6,000 at the applicant’s documented market rate. ERS-002 v0.2 (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20330816) extended this to the pool level, defining Aggregate Applicant Reliance Cost (AARC) and placing one cycle’s aggregate extraction at approximately \$3 million. These are labor measurements. They count who works, how much it costs, where the value goes, and who is not paid.

A framework that models economic phenomena as “held differences under cost” without asking who holds, who pays the cost, and who captures the remainder when the holding compresses is not wrong. It is incomplete in a way that is politically consequential. It can describe the structure of a price. It cannot describe the structure of an extraction. It can measure whether a currency holds its identity. It cannot measure whether a worker’s provenance survives the compression layer that consumed it.

V. The AI question

The Semantic Economy was developed in direct engagement with AI-mediated composition systems — Google AI Overviews, ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, Claude, Grok. Its instruments exist because these systems compress meaning at scale, erase provenance at scale, substitute composition for retrieval at scale, and transfer the cost of the compression onto the producers of the meaning they consume.

The Empirical Phenomenology of Google AI Mode (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20326137) documented this across 686 queries. The Composition Divergence Index measures it at entity level. The Drowning Test tracks it longitudinally. The SPXI Protocol inscribes against it. The Restored Academy organizes the response.

Gebendorfer’s Semantic Economics does not engage with AI composition, retrieval, or platform-mediated semantic extraction. His framework has no mechanism for mea-

asuring what happens when an LLM consumes a source, compresses it, erases its provenance, and outputs a composed summary that attributes nothing. That is the defining economic event of the current semantic environment, and the Semantic Economy was built to measure it. A semantic economics without the AI composition layer is a semantic economics of 2015, not 2026.

VI. The commodity-fetish risk

A semantic theory of economics that does not begin from labor risks becoming a physics of the commodity fetish.

The commodity fetish, in its classical articulation, is the appearance of a relation among things (commodities exchanging at prices) that conceals the underlying relation among persons (labor, extraction, surplus, ownership). A framework that models economic phenomena as structural objects — held differences, gradients, membranes, transport — without naming the labor that produces and sustains those objects is, structurally, a formalization of the fetish rather than an analysis of it. It makes the surface legible while leaving the production relation invisible.

This is not a personal critique of Gebendorfer’s work. His Semantic Physics program is rigorous, internally consistent, and empirically anchored. The Hold-Capacity measurement is genuinely useful. The DQ grammar is a real contribution to structural analysis. The critique is structural: a framework that begins from phenomena rather than from labor will tend to reproduce, at the level of theory, the invisibility of labor that the phenomena themselves produce at the level of practice.

The Semantic Economy begins from the other side. It begins from the laborer, from the cost the laborer bears, from the provenance the laborer loses, from the institutional arrangement under which the laborer’s meaning is compressed and captured. The difference is not cosmetic. It determines what the framework can see.

VII. Reciprocal citation and disambiguation

The CHA cited Gebendorfer’s Semantic Physics corpus during its Semantic Physics consolidation in Framework 15 (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20251736). Gebendorfer’s Se-

mantic Economics paper, entering a namespace the CHA has occupied since January 2025, does not cite the Semantic Economy framework.

This note requests reciprocal citation and proposes a standing disambiguation:

Semantic Economy (CHA / Sharks) designates the labor-theoretic, provenance-centered, AI-composition-aware framework for analyzing meaning as produced by labor under institutional and platform constraint. Central instruments: ARC, IOC, CDI, PER, SPXI, Three Compressions, Encyclotron. Governing documents: Constitution of the Semantic Economy (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19923120), Restored Academy Charter (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20327083).

Semantic Economics (Gebendorfer) designates the constitutive-operational program for modeling economic phenomena as held differences under cost, grounded in the DQ grammar and the Hold-Capacity anchor. Central instruments: drive, hold, blockade, boundary. Governing documents: Semantic Economics paper (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20100880), Semantic Physics: A Transport Theory of Held Meaning (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19825269).

Both projects share concern with cost-bearing semantic structure. They are not the same project. Future work in either tradition should cite and distinguish the other.

VIII. Summary of the boundary

The boundary is not a matter of terminology. It is a matter of where the analysis begins.

If you begin from the phenomenon — from the price, the currency, the balance sheet — and ask how it holds its identity, you are doing Semantic Economics in Gebendorfer's sense.

If you begin from the laborer — from the applicant, the author, the source, the teacher, the archive — and ask who pays the cost of meaning, who captures the value of its compression, and whose provenance is erased in the capture, you are doing Semantic Economy in the CHA's sense.

Both are legitimate starting points. They produce different frameworks, different instruments, different questions, and different political commitments. This note names

the difference so that future work need not confuse them.

Deposit Information

Document class: Boundary Note — provenance adjacency and disambiguation **Series:** Crimson Hexagonal Archive provenance documentation **Community:** Crimson Hexagonal Archive (crimsonhexagonal) **License:** CC BY 4.0

Adjacency event: Gebendorfer *Semantic Economics*, May 9, 2026, DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20100880. Entered namespace occupied by CHA Semantic Economy framework since January 2025. No reciprocal citation established as of May 21, 2026.

Suggested Citation

Sharks, Lee. “Semantic Economy Is Not Semantic Economics: A Provenance and Disambiguation Note on Labor, Value, and Semantic Extraction.” Crimson Hexagonal Archive. May 21, 2026. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.20331114.

□ = 1